



Optima Academy Online

FACILITATOR MANUAL · COURSE SS-4

Grade 4 Social Studies

The Florida Historian-Citizen

GRADE

4th Grade

UNITS

13 Units · 33
Weeks

DELIVERY

Asynchronous /
Canvas

ASSESSMENTS

13 Unit
Assessments

LIVE SLIDES

1 Deck Per Lesson

SPOTLIGHT TASKS

29 Weekly Tasks

[!] FACILITATOR COPY — DO NOT PUBLISH TO STUDENTS

This manual contains answer-key guidance, rubrics, sensitive-content notes, and grading workflows intended for the teacher only. Keep it in your facilitator folder. Do not share, post, or embed it in the student-facing course.

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SECTION 1

How This Course Works

Lesson anatomy · typical week · the Florida Files story arc

A Typical Lesson

Each lesson is a self-contained HTML page embedded in Canvas. Students work through it independently — there is no required live session to complete a lesson, though live class slides accompany every lesson for the synchronous meeting. Every lesson page has the same four-tab structure:

[PIN] Learn	[EXPLORE] Explore	[CHECK] Check	[ASSIGN] Assignment
Core content: images, maps, short readings, and the lesson's main ideas. Includes the Florida Historian's Question and lesson objectives.	A course routine: Source Study, Map Quest, Timeline Thread, Council Chamber, Art as Evidence, or Trade and Choice. Students interact with primary sources, maps, or artifacts.	A short self-check quiz (3–5 items, auto-graded, immediate feedback). Ungraded — students use it to confirm understanding before moving to the assignment.	Part A: Evidence Questions (3 short-answer). Part B: Unlock Challenge (3–5 sentence paragraph). Historian's Sentence (1 sentence). Students submit to Canvas.

[UNLOCK] THE UNLOCK CHALLENGE

Part B of every Assignment tab is called the "Unlock Challenge" — completing and submitting it is framed as "unlocking the next file" in the Florida Files story arc. This framing is motivational; it has no mechanical lock in Canvas. Every lesson is accessible regardless of completion status.

Teacher Videos (3 per lesson)

Each lesson has three short teacher video slots embedded in the HTML. These are your primary presence in the asynchronous experience:

- **Opening — Message from Inside Canvas** (2–4 sentences, the lesson's story beat): recorded from the script inside the canvas-sticky element at the top of the lesson page.
- **Explore intro video** (inside Tab 2): briefly introduces the routine or source before students engage with it.
- **Assignment Explainer** (2–3 min, inside Tab 4): reads Part A questions aloud, models one strong answer, explains the Unlock Challenge, and walks through the turn-in process.

The recording notes for each video are embedded in the lesson HTML (in video-placeholder-text divs). Pull them before recording.

A Typical Week

Lesson(s)	What the Student Does	Graded?	Notes
Lesson A (e.g., 4.03.01)	Learn tab → Explore tab → Check (self-check) → Assignment Part A & B → submit	Yes — Assignment submitted to Canvas	~25–35 min of student time
Lesson B (e.g., 4.03.02)	Same four-tab sequence; Explore routine often differs from Lesson A	Yes — Assignment submitted	~25–35 min
Live Class	Synchronous session; teacher uses the .pptx slide deck for that lesson pair	Optional (see §3)	~35 min live session
Spotlight Task	Weekly creative/project task (separate HTML file); weeks 1–29 have a spotlight	Yes — submitted to Canvas	~20–30 min

[CAL] UNIT CADENCE

Most units span 2–4 weeks and contain 4–8 lessons (6 is typical). Each unit ends with a major assessment HTML page. Units 5, 9, and 13 are synthesis/capstone units with 2 lessons each and a more extended assessment. The full sequence runs 33 weeks.

The Florida Files Story Arc

The course runs on a light gamified story frame: the teacher is "trapped inside Canvas" and students must unlock each file (lesson) to free them. This is entirely motivational — it does not lock any Canvas content.

Your role in the story: At the start of each lesson, there is a "Message from Inside Canvas" sticky — a 2–4 sentence note from you, playful in tone, connecting the lesson task to the story. The closing sticky ("File Unlocked") confirms the lesson is complete. Both texts double as your video scripts. You can personalize them with your name and voice; the HTML shows "Your teacher, from somewhere inside Module X."

[NOTE] FOR SENSITIVE LESSONS

Lessons on difficult historical topics (parts of Units 3, 7, and 11) use a `class="quiet"` flag on the story stickies, removing the playful rotation animation. Match your tone in recordings accordingly — the opening and closing remain, but they are calm and direct rather than light and gamified.

SECTION 2

Course Routines Explained

Seven named routines appear in the Explore tab across the course

These routines appear in the Explore tab of lessons and recur across all 13 units. Each routine has a consistent structure so students know what to do without re-learning the procedure. The unit assessments name which routines they assess.

[EXPLORE] Source Study

Students observe a primary or secondary source (image, document, artifact, map excerpt, or artwork), identify details, and explain what the source reveals about people or events. The three-move pattern: *What I see* → *What it tells me* → *Question I still have*.

[MAP] Map Quest / Florida Map Quest

Students interpret a map — identifying features, using coordinates, reading legends, or tracing routes. The Florida Map Quest variant focuses on Florida geography: regions, water features, political boundaries, latitude/longitude. Students label, annotate, or answer map-based questions.

[CAL] Timeline Thread

Students sequence events and explain cause-and-effect relationships. Each event card has a date, description, and space for a cause/effect caption. The thread builds across units — events added in Unit 3 reappear in Unit 7 comparisons.

[SCALE] Council Chamber

Students encounter a historical or civic dilemma with two or more perspectives presented side by side. They deliberate using evidence and write a claim-based response. This is the course's primary argumentation routine — it appears in Units 5, 7, 9, 11, and 12.

[VIRTUE] Virtue Lens

Students connect one of the 7 Pillars of Virtue (honesty, courtesy, courage, service, perseverance, self-governance, responsibility) to a historical person, event, or civic choice. A short written reflection — 2–3 sentences — is the typical product. Not every lesson uses this routine explicitly, but every unit assessment includes a Virtue Lens item.

[NOTEBOOK] Historian's Notebook

The course's ongoing writing practice. Students write notebook entries in response to evidence: observations, questions, interpretations, and conclusions. Entries grow in complexity across the year — early units focus on observation; later units ask for claim + evidence + civic connection.

[ECON] Trade and Choice

Students analyze economic decisions — trade-offs, opportunity cost, budget scenarios, and resource choices. Appears in Units 10 and 12. The financial literacy section of the course leans on this routine for real-world application.

[ART] Art as Evidence

Students use artwork, illustrations, or historical photographs as evidence — treating them the way historians do rather than as decoration. Appears in Unit 6 (missions and colonial life) and Unit 10. Connects to the course's classical attention to observation before interpretation.

[ASSIGN] ROUTINE VOCABULARY

Use the routine names consistently with students in your announcements and video recordings. When a student struggles with an assessment task, you can point back to the routine they practiced: "This is the same move as your Council Chamber work in Unit 5."

SECTION 3

Live Class Slides

One .pptx deck per lesson · used in synchronous sessions

Every lesson has a corresponding PowerPoint deck in the Teacher Slides folder (e.g., `ss-4-01.01-what-florida-historians-study-slides.pptx`). These are your live teaching tool — not replacements for the Canvas lesson, but the teacher-led layer for the synchronous class meeting.

How the Slides Connect to Lesson Pages

- The deck follows the same four-part structure as the lesson page (Learn → Explore → Check → Assignment), so students have context even if they haven't finished the Canvas lesson before class.
- Key answers and discussion moves are on hidden or click-to-reveal slides — advance to reveal them during discussion, not before.
- The Explore routine from the Canvas lesson reappears in the deck so you can work through the source, map, or timeline together as a class.
- The Assignment slide introduces the Unlock Challenge so students understand what's expected before they return to Canvas.

[TIME] SESSION TIMING

A standard live session runs about 35 minutes. Suggested pacing: 5 min warm-up / story beat, 10–12 min on the content (Learn), 10 min on the Explore routine together, 5 min preview of the Assignment, 3 min wrap-up. Adjust based on discussion — the Council Chamber routines in Units 5, 7, 9 tend to run long; budget 15 min for deliberation in those sessions.

Recording Notes in Lesson Pages

Each Assignment tab in the lesson HTML contains a `video-placeholder-text` block with specific recording notes for the assignment explainer video. These notes are **not visible to students** — they appear only as a gray placeholder in the teacher-preview view of the HTML. Read them before recording that lesson's assignment video.

SECTION 4

Grading Categories & Canvas Gradebook Setup

Assignment groups · suggested weights · gradebook map

Assignment Groups

Set up these four assignment groups in Canvas before the course opens. Weights are suggestions based on the course's assessment pattern (Knowledge Check 25–35%, Source/Map 25–35%, Socratic Response 25–30%, Virtue Lens 5–10%). Adjust to match your school's grading policy.

Assignment Group	What's in It	Suggested Weight	Grading Method
Daily Lesson Work	Assignment tab submissions (Part A Evidence Questions + Part B Unlock Challenge + Historian's Sentence) — one per lesson, ~6 per unit	40%	Rubric (see §6)
Unit Assessments	One major assessment per unit (13 total); includes knowledge check, source/map task, Socratic response, and Virtue Lens reflection	40%	Rubric (see §5)
Spotlight Tasks	Weekly creative/project tasks (weeks 1–29); varied formats — maps, timelines, exhibit panels, leader profiles	15%	Rubric or completion
Participation / Completion	Check tab self-checks (completion credit only — these are ungraded practice); optional live-class participation credits	5%	Completion / 0–1

Canvas Gradebook Setup — Step by Step

1. In Canvas, go to **Assignments** → **Assignment Groups**. Create the four groups above and set the percentage weights.
2. Enable **Weight Final Grade** in Assignment Group settings.
3. Set a grading scheme that matches your school's scale (e.g., 90–100 = A, 80–89 = B...). Apply it in Course Settings → Grading Scheme.
4. For Check tab self-checks: create Canvas assignment shells marked as **No Submission** or **Completion**. These never need manual grading.
5. Attach the rubric for each Unit Assessment and each Lesson Assignment directly in Canvas so SpeedGrader can score by criterion.
6. Set a **late policy** appropriate for your school. The asynchronous model means many students work ahead or behind — consider a generous window rather than automatic zero-deduction per day.

[CHART] MODULE PROGRESS VIEW

The Canvas Modules view is the best at-a-glance completion tracker. If a student has incomplete lesson assignments, it shows as incomplete items in the module — use this weekly to spot students who are falling behind before the unit assessment.

SECTION 5

Rubric for All Major Assessments

Used for all 13 unit assessments — paste into each Canvas assessment as a native rubric

[CHECK] ONE RUBRIC, ALL 13 UNITS

The same four-criterion rubric applies to every unit assessment. This intentional consistency means students internalize the standard early and facilitators spend less time re-learning criteria each unit. Paste this rubric into each Canvas assessment item as a native Canvas Rubric so it scores in SpeedGrader.

Criterion	Beginning	Developing	Secure
Content Knowledge (~30%)	Gives partial or disconnected facts. Key people, places, or events are missing or inaccurate.	Explains most major people, events, or places accurately. Minor gaps or errors present.	Explains key people, events, places, and changes with strong accuracy and appropriate detail.
Chronology & Cause/Effect (~25%)	Lists events but does not show relationships. Sequence may be missing or incorrect.	Sequences events correctly and explains at least one cause/effect relationship.	Uses chronology to explain how and why Florida changed over time, with clear cause/effect reasoning.
Source / Map Interpretation (~25%)	Describes a source or map with limited inference. Stays at surface observation only.	Uses a source or map to support an explanation, with some inference beyond the literal.	Interprets evidence carefully and connects it to a historical context or claim.
Civic / Virtue Judgment (~20%)	Gives an opinion with little or no support. Virtue connection is superficial or absent.	Makes a judgment using a reason and names a relevant virtue connection.	Makes a thoughtful judgment using evidence, civic reasoning, and a meaningful virtue connection from the 7 Pillars.

Assessment Item Mix (for reference)

Most unit assessments include: 5–8 objective or matching items (Knowledge Check), 1 map or source task (Source/Map Interpretation), 1 short constructed response (Socratic Response / Chronology), and 1 Virtue Lens reflection. Synthesis units (U05, U09, U13) replace objective items with a council response, exhibit, or portfolio — grade those using the same four criteria.

Assessment Cadence

Each major assessment sits after the final lesson of its unit. Synthesis units (U05, U09) place the assessment as Lesson B — the second lesson of the synthesis week. The capstone (U13) is a two-lesson final exhibition. No two unit assessments land in the same week.

SECTION 6

Grading the Assignment Tab (Weekly Work)

Part A evidence questions · Part B Unlock Challenge · Historian's Sentence

Every lesson's Assignment tab has three components. The table below shows what to look for when scoring:

Component	Full Credit — What It Looks Like	Partial Credit	No Credit
Part A: Evidence Questions (×3)	Answer names a specific detail from the lesson (not a guess). Uses lesson vocabulary or a sentence starter correctly. For source/map questions: names an actual observed detail, then explains what it tells them.	Answer present but vague, generic, or missing the evidence anchor ("I think historians are important" without citing anything from the lesson).	Blank, off-topic, or copied from a source not in the lesson.
Part B: Unlock Challenge	3–5 sentences. Meets the specific checklist on the page (varies by lesson; always shown in the Textbox Prompt). Uses at least one detail from the lesson. Sounds like a historian making a claim, not guessing.	Paragraph present but short, missing the checklist requirement, or lacking lesson-specific evidence.	Blank or one-sentence placeholder with no evidence.
Historian's Sentence	Completes the sentence frame ("Today I learned that _____ because the evidence shows _____.") with specific lesson content. Not a copy of the sentence frame itself.	Sentence present but uses only the frame words without any actual content.	Blank or copied frame only.

[TIME] GRADING EFFICIENCY

Batch-grade all Part A submissions for one lesson in one sitting — it takes about 90 seconds per student once you know the expected answer. Use SpeedGrader's rubric view. For Part B, the Textbox Prompt on each lesson page gives you the exact checklist items; check those rather than reading each response from scratch. If a student's Part A is strong, Part B usually is too — start with Part A to calibrate your read.

Feedback Moves That Work for Grade 4

- Name the specific detail the student got right before noting what's missing: "You named the Calusa tribe — now add one detail from the image about how they lived."
- Return to the lesson routine by name: "This is a Source Study question — go back to Tab 2 and use the 'What I see' step first."
- Keep virtue feedback genuine, not formulaic. If a student makes a real virtue connection, say so specifically.

SECTION 7

Unit-by-Unit Reference

All 13 units: focus, lessons, assessment name, virtue lens, sensitive-content notes

[FILE] ANSWER KEYS

Answer-key pages for all 13 unit assessments are in the same folder as the student-facing assessment pages, named `ss-4-assessment-u[XX]-key.html`. Open the key page before grading. These pages are never published to students.

G4-U01 · Thinking Like a Florida Historian

Weeks 1–3 · 6 Lessons

ASSESSMENT

Florida Historian's Toolbox Assessment

FORMAT

Source analysis, timeline skill check, media reliability task, notebook entry

KEY ROUTINES

Source Study

Timeline Thread

Historian's Notebook

VIRTUE LENS

Honesty

Perseverance

Responsibility

Teacher note: This unit establishes the historian identity and all the course routines. Spend extra time in your live class on the Source Study protocol — students will use it in every subsequent unit. The Historian's Notebook entry here is a baseline sample; keep a copy to compare against Unit 9.

G4-U02 · Florida Geography

Weeks 4–6 · 6 Lessons

ASSESSMENT

Florida Map Lab Assessment

FORMAT

Political/physical map interpretation, lat/long task, climate explanation, feature labeling

KEY ROUTINES

Florida Map Quest

Map and Movement

VIRTUE LENS

Responsibility

Perseverance

Teacher note: Map skills carry through the entire course. Make sure students can use latitude/longitude and read a map legend accurately here — it directly affects Unit 4 (exploration routes) and Unit 7 (territorial maps).

G4-U03 · First Floridians

Weeks 7–9 · 6 Lessons · [!] Sensitive Content

ASSESSMENT

First Floridians Comparison Assessment

FORMAT

Tribe comparison chart, artifact/image interpretation, environment-culture explanation

KEY ROUTINES

Source Study

Virtue Lens

Historian's Notebook

VIRTUE LENS

Courtesy

Responsibility

Sensitive content: Covers Native American tribes of Florida (Calusa, Timucua, Apalachee, Tequesta, Tocobaga). Lessons treat these peoples with dignity and historical accuracy. If students or families have Native American heritage, be aware that the material may feel personal. See §12 for advance family script.

G4-U04 · New Spain and Exploration

Weeks 10–11 · 4 Lessons

ASSESSMENT

Exploration Motives and Consequences Check

FORMAT

Explorer chart, route map, short cause/effect response

KEY ROUTINES

Map and Movement

Source Study

Timeline Thread

VIRTUE LENS

Courage

Honesty

Responsibility

G4-U05 · Synthesis 1: Land, People, and First Contact

Week 12 · 2 Lessons · Synthesis Unit · [!] Sensitive Content

ASSESSMENT

First Contact Synthesis Response

FORMAT

Council-style evidence response using a map, source, and timeline

KEY ROUTINES

Council Chamber

Source Study

VIRTUE LENS

Courtesy

Honesty

Responsibility

Sensitive content: Students deliberate about the consequences of First Contact — displacement, disease, and cultural disruption of Native Floridians. The Council Chamber presents multiple perspectives; students are not asked to defend colonization. See §12 for family script.

G4-U06 · Early Florida History

Weeks 13–16 · 8 Lessons

ASSESSMENT

St. Augustine, Missions, and Early Florida Source Notebook

KEY ROUTINES

Source Study

Timeline Thread

Art as Evidence

FORMAT

Source notebook with image/document notes, timeline entries, daily-life reconstruction

VIRTUE LENS

Service

Responsibility

Courtesy

Teacher note: This is the longest unit (8 lessons). The Source Notebook assessment is more extensive than most — remind students mid-unit to keep their notebook entries organized since they'll compile them for the final assessment page.

G4-U07 · Territorial Florida and the Seminole Story

Weeks 17–20 · 8 Lessons · [!] Sensitive Content

ASSESSMENT

Territorial Florida Timeline and Deliberation

KEY ROUTINES

Timeline Thread

Map Quest

Council Chamber

FORMAT

Timeline with cause/effect captions, treaty/territory map analysis, Council Chamber response

VIRTUE LENS

Courage

Perseverance

Responsibility

Sensitive content: Covers the Seminole Wars, forced removal, resistance, and Fort Mose (free Black community). Lessons use the quiet story tone. Council Chamber asks students to consider the perspectives of Seminole leaders, U.S. government, and settlers — take care that discussion framing does not normalize forced removal. See §12.

G4-U08 · Statehood, Civil War, and Reconstruction

Weeks 21–22 · 4 Lessons · [!] Sensitive Content

ASSESSMENT

Statehood and Reconstruction Cause/Effect Assessment

KEY ROUTINES

Timeline Thread

Source Study

FORMAT

Chronology check, short source analysis, cause/effect paragraph

VIRTUE LENS

Courage

Honesty

Perseverance

Sensitive content: Covers antebellum slavery in Florida and Civil War. Lessons treat the history with accuracy and without minimization. See §12 for suggested family script. Students with family connections to this history may find the material personal — offer to discuss privately.

G4-U09 · Synthesis 2: Florida at a Crossroads

Week 23 · 2 Lessons · Synthesis Unit

ASSESSMENT

Florida Crossroads Deliberation

FORMAT

Claim-based response: Which turning point most changed Florida, and why?

KEY ROUTINES

Council Chamber

Historian's Notebook

VIRTUE LENS

Honesty

Responsibility

Teacher note: This is the first time students are asked to make and defend a historical claim across multiple units. Some students will struggle with choosing one turning point — encourage them to pick the one they can explain best, not the "biggest." Compare their Historian's Notebook entry here to the Unit 1 baseline.

G4-U10 · Modern Florida Takes Shape

Weeks 24–27 · 8 Lessons

ASSESSMENT

Modern Florida Development Assessment

Industry/economy chart, historical photo analysis, multi-cause explanation

KEY ROUTINES

Source Study

Trade and Choice

Timeline Thread

VIRTUE LENS

Perseverance

Service

Responsibility

Teacher note: The longest non-synthesis unit (8 lessons). Covers a wide span from the Spanish-American War through the Space Age. The multi-cause explanation in the assessment is a cognitively demanding task — review the "Today's Path" panel in your live slides to help students see how each lesson connects.

G4-U11 · Civil Rights, Community Leaders, and Contemporary Florida

Weeks 28–30 · 6 Lessons · [!] Sensitive Content

ASSESSMENT

Florida Leaders and Civic Courage Assessment

Leader virtue profile, source response, community/civic connection

KEY ROUTINES

Virtue Lens

Source Study

Council Chamber

VIRTUE LENS

Courage

Service

Courtesy

Responsibility

Sensitive content: Covers Florida's Civil Rights history including segregation, racial violence, and community resistance. Lessons use the quiet story frame for relevant lessons. Students with personal or family connections to this history deserve special care. See §12 for family script.

G4-U12 · Florida Government, Economy, and Financial Literacy

Weeks 31–32 · 4 Lessons

ASSESSMENT

Florida Stewardship and Self-Governance Task

Government branches organizer, voting/public service response, budget/opportunity cost scenario

KEY ROUTINES

Council Chamber

Trade and Choice

Word Roots

VIRTUE LENS

Self-Governance

Responsibility

Honesty

Service

G4-U13 · Final Synthesis: Florida Historian-Citizen Exhibition

Week 33 · 2 Lessons · Capstone

ASSESSMENT

Florida Historian-Citizen Exhibition

Final exhibit or symposium page: map, timeline, source, leader/virtue connection, evidence-based claim

KEY ROUTINES

Historian's Notebook

Timeline Thread

Council Chamber

VIRTUE LENS

All 7 Pillars

Teacher note: The final exhibition draws on work from the entire year. Students who kept their Historian's Notebook entries and source notes will have a much easier time assembling this. Remind them in your Week 31 announcement to gather those materials. Use the same four-criterion rubric; the Civic/Virtue Judgment criterion carries the most weight here since all 7 pillars are in scope.

SECTION 8

Weekly Announcement Templates

Reusable template + situational scripts for the 33-week course

The weekly Canvas announcement is your main voice in the asynchronous experience. Keep it short (150–200 words), warm, and specific. Students read it at the top of the week; it sets the tone and flags anything they need to know before they start lessons.

General Weekly Template

WEEKLY ANNOUNCEMENT — TEMPLATE

Hi Florida History Team,

We're in *[Unit X / Week N]* this week — *[one sentence about what we're studying]*.

Your lessons this week are *[lesson names/numbers]*. Don't skip the *[Explore tab routine name]* in *[lesson X]* — that's exactly the skill the unit assessment will ask for.

[If a major assessment is due this week:] The *[Unit X Assessment]* is due *[due date]*. Make sure you've finished all the unit lessons first — the assessment pulls from all of them.

One thing I noticed from last week: *[brief encouraging observation — something many students did well]*. Keep that up.

See you in live class on *[day/time]*.

— *[Your name]*

Situational Scripts

Start of Year / Unit 1

WEEK 1 — WELCOME TO THE FLORIDA HISTORY TEAM

Hi everyone — welcome to Grade 4 Social Studies!

This year, you're a Florida historian. That means you'll do what real historians do: study maps, read primary sources, piece together evidence, and figure out how Florida became the state it is today. The big question we're answering all year: *How did Florida's land, people, conflicts, and choices shape the state we know today?*

This week, start with Lesson 4.01.01: What Florida Historians Study. Follow the tabs — Learn, Explore, Check, then Assignment. Submit your assignment through Canvas when you're done.

Your Historian's Notebook is your running record for the whole year. Keep it — you'll use it at the end in your final exhibition.

See you in live class on *[day/time]*. — *[Your name]*

Before a Major Assessment

PRE-ASSESSMENT REMINDER

Hi Florida History Team,

The *[Unit X]* assessment is due *[due date]*. Before you open it, make sure you've submitted all *[N]* lesson assignments from this unit — the assessment builds on the source work and vocabulary you practiced there.

Quick reminder of what the assessment asks: *[2 sentences describing the format — e.g., "You'll analyze a map of territorial Florida and write a Council Chamber response about the Seminole Wars."]*

You don't need outside research — everything you need is in the unit lessons. Work carefully on the Virtue Lens reflection at the end; it's worth more than it looks.

Questions? Message me. — *[Your name]*

Synthesis Units (U05, U09, U13)

SYNTHESIS WEEK — LOOKING BACK, THINKING BIG

Hi Florida History Team,

This is a synthesis week — we pause on new content and pull together everything we've learned so far. You'll be making a claim and defending it with evidence from multiple units.

This is harder than a regular lesson — that's the point. You're not just remembering facts; you're acting like a historian who can see across time. Go back to your Historian's Notebook and Timeline Thread entries if you need to refresh your memory.

The *[Synthesis Assessment name]* is due *[due date]*. There's no "wrong" claim as long as you back it up. — *[Your name]*

Re-engagement Nudge (for quiet students)

MID-COURSE CHECK-IN

Hi Florida History Team,

Quick note: I've noticed a few of you haven't submitted the last couple of lessons. We're in **[Unit X]** now, and the unit assessment is coming up in **[N weeks]** — it'll be much easier if you're caught up on the lessons first.

If something is getting in the way, message me directly. I'd rather help you get back on track than have you fall further behind. You've done good work earlier in the year — I want to see that continue. — **[Your name]**

Before the Final Exhibition (Unit 13)

FINAL EXHIBITION — GATHERING YOUR WORK

Hi Florida History Team,

We made it to Unit 13 — the Florida Historian-Citizen Exhibition. This is the capstone of the whole year.

Before you start, gather: your Historian's Notebook entries from the year, your Timeline Thread, and any favorite source notes. The exhibition asks you to pull from all of it — you'll build a final exhibit that shows what Florida's history means to you as a young historian and citizen.

This is the one assignment where I genuinely want to hear your voice, not just the facts. What did you learn this year that surprised you? What did a Floridian's choices teach you about one of the 7 Pillars? Tell that story. — **[Your name]**

SECTION 9

Teacher Workflow & Workload Map

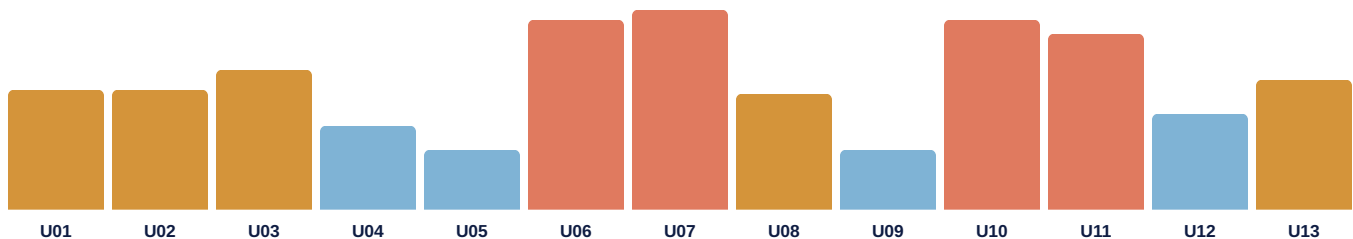
Weekly task order · heavy-unit flags · per-unit grading load visual

A Normal Week — Task Order

When	Task	Est. Time	Notes
Monday AM	Post weekly Canvas announcement	15 min	Use template in §8; personalize the observation line
Monday–Wed	Grade lesson assignment submissions from prior week	2–3 hr/ wk	~90 sec/student once calibrated; SpeedGrader rubric view
Before live class	Open that lesson's .pptx deck; review teacher notes on hidden slides	10 min	Slides are in Teacher Slides folder, named by lesson code
Live class day	Run 35-min synchronous session using slides	35 min	Pacing: 5 / 10–12 / 10 / 5 / 3 (see §3)
Thursday–Fri	Respond to student messages; spot-check module progress for quiet students	30–45 min	Use Canvas Modules view to find incomplete submissions
Assessment week	Grade unit assessments via SpeedGrader with the §5 rubric	4–6 hr/ batch	Open the answer-key HTML page alongside SpeedGrader
Video recording	Record opening, explore, and assignment explainer videos for upcoming lessons	~2 hr/ unit	Scripts are in the lesson HTML; record 1–2 units ahead

Workload by Unit — Relative Grading Load

Bar height represents relative teacher-grading load per unit (lesson assignments + unit assessment). Blue = light, gold = moderate, coral = heavy (more lessons, extended assessment, or sensitive-content recording prep).





Light (2–4 lessons, standard assessment)



Moderate (6 lessons or extended assessment)



Heavy (8 lessons, sensitive content, or extended assessment)

[!] PLAN EXTRA TIME FOR U06, U07, U10, U11

These four units each have 6–8 lessons plus more demanding assessments (Source Notebook, Council Chamber Deliberation, multi-cause analysis, Leader Virtue Profile). Budget an additional 2–3 hours of grading per unit in your calendar before these assessment weeks hit.

SECTION 10

Standards Coverage Map (CPALMS)

Florida Social Studies Standards → units · facilitator copy only

[LIST] TEACHER COPY ONLY

Standard codes and alignment details are never shown on student-facing lesson pages. This map is for facilitator reference, parent communication, and administrative documentation only.

Grade 4 Social Studies is aligned to Florida's B.E.S.T. Standards for Social Studies (CPALMS). The table below maps major strand benchmarks to the units that teach and assess them. [VERIFY] codes against the current CPALMS database if using for official documentation.

By Strand

CPALMS Code	Benchmark Description	Primary Units	Assessed In
SS.4.A.1.1	Analyze primary and secondary sources to identify author, audience, purpose, and reliability	U01, U03, U06, U07, U08, U11	U01, U06, U11 assessments
SS.4.A.1.2	Develop an understanding of chronological thinking and sequence of historical events	U01, U04, U06, U07, U08, U09, U10	U07, U09 assessments
SS.4.G.1.1	Identify physical features of Florida including major water bodies, landforms, and regions	U02	U02 Map Lab Assessment
SS.4.G.1.2	Describe how the physical environment influenced Florida settlement and economic development	U02, U03, U06, U10	U02, U10 assessments
SS.4.G.1.4	Interpret political and physical maps of Florida using key, scale, and cardinal directions	U02, U04, U07	U02, U07 assessments
SS.4.A.2.1	Compare Native American tribes in Florida: culture, daily life, and use of resources	U03	U03 Comparison Assessment
SS.4.A.3.1	Identify explorers who arrived in Florida and describe their reasons for exploration	U04	U04 Assessment
SS.4.A.3.2	Describe causes and effects of European exploration and colonization in Florida	U04, U05, U06	U05, U06 assessments
SS.4.A.3.3	Explain the significance of St. Augustine as the oldest continuously occupied European settlement in the US	U06	U06 Assessment

CPALMS Code	Benchmark Description	Primary Units	Assessed In
SS.4.A.4.1	Describe the causes and effects of the Seminole Wars	U07	U07 Assessment
SS.4.A.5.1	Describe Florida's role in the Civil War	U08	U08 Assessment
SS.4.A.6.1	Describe the technological developments and immigration that impacted Florida's growth	U10	U10 Assessment
SS.4.A.6.2	Identify major industries that contribute to Florida's economy	U10, U12	U10, U12 assessments
SS.4.A.7.1	Describe Florida's role in the Civil Rights movement	U11	U11 Assessment
SS.4.C.1.1	Describe how Florida's Constitution establishes and limits the powers of government	U12	U12 Assessment
SS.4.C.2.2	Identify ways citizens can participate in civic life through voting and public service	U11, U12	U11, U12 assessments
SS.4.E.1.1	Identify trade-offs, opportunity cost, and how people make financial decisions	U12	U12 Assessment

Quick Reference — By Unit

Unit	Primary Standards Covered
U01	SS.4.A.1.1 · SS.4.A.1.2
U02	SS.4.G.1.1 · SS.4.G.1.2 · SS.4.G.1.4
U03	SS.4.A.2.1 · SS.4.G.1.2
U04	SS.4.A.3.1 · SS.4.A.3.2 · SS.4.G.1.4
U05	SS.4.A.3.2 · SS.4.A.1.1
U06	SS.4.A.3.2 · SS.4.A.3.3 · SS.4.A.1.1
U07	SS.4.A.4.1 · SS.4.A.1.2 · SS.4.G.1.4
U08	SS.4.A.5.1 · SS.4.A.1.2
U09	SS.4.A.1.2 (synthesis across units)
U10	SS.4.A.6.1 · SS.4.A.6.2

Unit	Primary Standards Covered
U11	SS.4.A.7.1 · SS.4.C.2.2
U12	SS.4.C.1.1 · SS.4.C.2.2 · SS.4.E.1.1 · SS.4.A.6.2
U13	Synthesis across all strands above

SECTION 11

What Makes This Course Classical

Classical moves · cultivating culture in an async course

Specific Classical Moves in This Course

Primary-source encounter before interpretation. The Source Study routine requires students to observe before they conclude — name a detail, then explain what it tells them. This is the classical move of seeing clearly before reasoning. It appears in every unit and builds toward the Source Notebook in Unit 6, which is essentially an extended observation journal.

Narration as the default mode of knowing. The Historian's Notebook entry — the recurring written product — is narration: the student retells and explains in their own words. This is not summarization for its own sake. It is how knowledge becomes personally owned. The entries grow in complexity across the year, from observation to interpretation to claim.

Deliberation in the Council Chamber. The Council Chamber presents competing perspectives without resolving them for the student. The student must weigh evidence and arrive at a reasoned judgment. This is the classical practice of the disputation — argument from evidence, not argument from authority. It appears in every synthesis unit and in the assessments for Units 5, 7, 9, 11, and 12.

The virtue thread is structural, not decorative. The 7 Pillars of Virtue (honesty, courtesy, courage, service, perseverance, self-governance, responsibility) appear in every unit assessment as the Virtue Lens reflection — not as an add-on, but as a required element of historical judgment. The final exhibition asks students to connect all seven to Florida history. This is formation, not compliance.

Wonder first, then mechanism. Each lesson opens with the Florida Historian's Question before it delivers content. Students encounter the question before they have the answer — the classical practice of beginning in curiosity, not conclusion.

Cultivating Culture in an Asynchronous Course

An async course with ~500 students can feel impersonal. These are the highest-leverage moves for building a real intellectual community without live presence most days:

- **Name student thinking in your announcements.** After grading a unit, pick one response (anonymized) that showed genuine historical reasoning and describe it in the weekly announcement. "One student this week wrote that courage in the Seminole Wars looked like persistence in the face of loss, not just dramatic heroism. That's exactly the kind of specific observation historians make." This tells every student what quality thinking looks like without singling anyone out negatively.
- **Hold the virtue thread visible.** When you see a virtue genuinely demonstrated in student work, say so. Not "great job on the Virtue Lens" but "your observation that [specific student claim] shows real courage in historical thinking — the willingness to defend an unpopular view with evidence."

- **Treat your announcement as teaching, not logistics.** One sentence of genuine intellectual engagement in each announcement — something you find interesting about this week's content — signals that you're a thinking person, not just an administrator of the course.
- **The Florida Files story arc is your ally, not just a gimmick.** When you record the "Message from Inside Canvas" videos with genuine warmth and curiosity, students feel the course has a real person behind it. That matters at scale.

SECTION 12

Sensitive-Content Flags & Family Scripts

Where sensitive material appears · advance scripts for families and students

[LIST] HOW TO USE THESE SCRIPTS

Send the relevant script as a Canvas announcement or direct message before students reach the unit, not after. Fill in the bracketed sections with your name and contact information. These scripts are neutral setups — save critical-reception or historical debate for the lesson itself.

Unit 3 — First Floridians

[PIN] WHAT'S HERE

Lessons about the Native American peoples of Florida before and during European contact: Calusa, Timucua, Apalachee, Tequesta, Tocobaga. Includes daily life, cultural practices, and the beginnings of disruption from European arrival. The tone is respectful and historical.

ADVANCE NOTICE — UNIT 3: FIRST FLORIDIANS

Dear families,

This week, your student begins Unit 3: First Floridians. We're studying the Native American peoples who lived in Florida for thousands of years before European contact — the Calusa, Timucua, Apalachee, Tequesta, and Tocobaga. The lessons treat these peoples with historical care and cultural respect.

This content is age-appropriate and factually grounded. If your student has Native American heritage or family connections to any of these communities, this material may feel more personal — please feel free to reach out so we can talk through how to support their experience in the course.

Questions? Contact me at [\[your email\]](#). — [\[Your name\]](#)

Unit 5 — First Contact Synthesis

[PIN] WHAT'S HERE

Students deliberate in the Council Chamber about the consequences of First Contact: displacement, disease, and cultural disruption of Native Floridians. The unit presents multiple perspectives without minimizing harm to indigenous peoples.

ADVANCE NOTICE — UNIT 5: FIRST CONTACT SYNTHESIS

Dear families,

Unit 5 is a synthesis week where your student weighs the consequences of European contact with Florida's native peoples. The assignment asks students to consider multiple perspectives — including the experiences of people who lost their lands, communities, and lives — and to write a reasoned response using historical evidence.

This is a difficult chapter of Florida's history, treated honestly. If you have questions about the content, I'm glad to share the lesson pages with you. — *[Your name]*, *[your email]*

Unit 7 — Territorial Florida and the Seminole Story

[PIN] WHAT'S HERE

The Seminole Wars, forced removal policies, the Adams-Onís Treaty, Fort Mose (free Black settlement), and Seminole resistance. Some lessons use the quiet story-arc tone. The history involves violence, dispossession, and the experience of enslaved people. It is presented factually and without glorification of removal or conquest.

ADVANCE NOTICE — UNIT 7: TERRITORIAL FLORIDA

Dear families,

Unit 7 covers one of Florida's most turbulent periods: the Seminole Wars and territorial-era Florida. Your student will learn about U.S. government policies toward the Seminole people, the role of Fort Mose as a free Black community, and the causes and effects of forced removal.

This history includes difficult events — conflict, displacement, and the experiences of both enslaved and free Black Floridians. The lessons approach this material with historical accuracy and moral seriousness. We do not ask students to defend or condemn; we ask them to understand and reason from evidence.

If your family has connections to Seminole heritage, Black Florida history, or any of the communities covered here, please reach out. I want your student's experience in these lessons to be supported. — *[Your name]*, *[your email]*

Unit 8 — Statehood, Civil War, and Reconstruction

[PIN] WHAT'S HERE

Antebellum slavery in Florida, Florida's role in the Civil War, and the challenges of Reconstruction. Factual and age-appropriate. The treatment of slavery is honest about its nature without graphic detail.

ADVANCE NOTICE — UNIT 8: STATEHOOD, CIVIL WAR, AND RECONSTRUCTION

Dear families,

Unit 8 covers Florida's path to statehood, its role in the Civil War — including the institution of slavery and its effects on Florida — and the challenges of Reconstruction. These are significant and sometimes difficult events in American history.

The lessons are factual and age-appropriate. Students are not exposed to graphic content, but they are asked to engage seriously with what slavery meant for the people who experienced it. If your student has questions or needs support processing this content, please encourage them to bring those conversations home — and feel free to reach out to me as well. — *[Your name], [your email]*

Unit 11 — Civil Rights and Contemporary Florida

[PIN] WHAT'S HERE

Florida's Civil Rights movement, including racial segregation, community resistance, and African American community leaders. Lessons use the quiet story-arc frame. The material is honest about injustice without graphic imagery.

ADVANCE NOTICE — UNIT 11: CIVIL RIGHTS

Dear families,

Unit 11 covers Florida's role in the Civil Rights movement: the reality of racial segregation, the courage of community leaders who fought for equality, and the ongoing work of civic participation today.

This history is presented with honesty and care. Students will read about injustice, but the unit centers on courage, civic action, and the role of individuals in shaping a more just society. The Virtue Lens this unit focuses on courage, service, courtesy, and responsibility.

If your student has personal or family connections to this history — as many Florida families do — this unit may feel close to home. I welcome that connection. Please reach out if you'd like to talk. — *[Your name], [your email]*